Excavation to Publication: Examining Kassite Tablets from Nippur

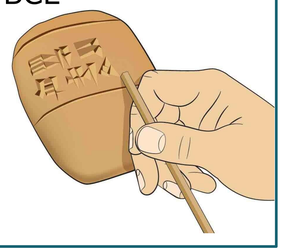
Bryce Hoenigman
Research Mentor: Prof. Susanne Paulus, Tablet Collection Team

THE UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO
INSTITUTE FOR THE STUDY OF ANCIENT CULTURES
West Asia & North Africa

Background

Cuneiform

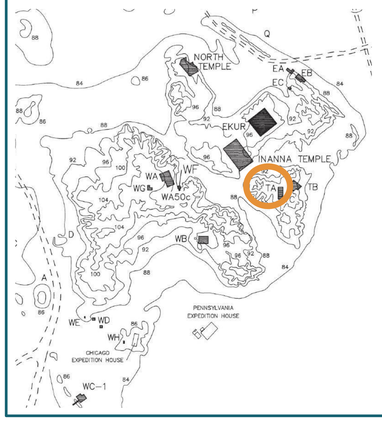
- **What**: Considered the oldest writing system, used for many different ancient languages of the Middle East, such as Akkadian, Sumerian, and Hittite
- **When**:~3000-0 BCE
- **How**: Imprinted by indenting styli onto wet clay surfaces resulting in a 3D effect



Nippur

- **When**: Occupation of the site extends back to the Ubaid period, though this project looks at tablets dating to the Kassite period (~13th century BCE)
- **What**: Seat of Enlil (king of gods), making this city the realm's most important religious center
- **Where**:~125mi South of present Baghdad
- **Nippur Tablet Hill**: Known as the Scribal Quarter, this mound is South East of the Ziggurat





The Northern half of Area TA level IV is identified as a Kassite period domestic area

Method

A step-by-step walk-through with A30078

1. Contextualizing the tablet: A30078 is part of a larger archive dating to the reigns of Kadašman-Enlil II and Kudur-Enlil (~1263-1246 BCE). Reading can help provide context about genre. This tablet, for instance, likely held a lengthy legal matter.

2. Investigating shape: Because of the horizontal striations present on the top edge, we know only the bottom of this tablet is preserved. We are left to predict what may have existed in the missing portion…





The obverse likely stated the reason why the payments were made.

The reverse likely contained further final clauses, witnesses, and the date.



Transliteration:

1′ [...]
2′ *i-na* ŠU $^{m.d}$*nin-urta-qar-rad*
3′ ^{m}*ta-ri-bu ma-[ḫi]-ir*
4′ [1+];1.2.0 ^{še}MUNU$_6$ ^{giš}BAN$_2$ GAL KI.MIN KI.MIN
5′ [0;0.x.0^{1} I$_3$.GIŠ ^{giš}BAN$_2$ GAL KI.MIN KI.MIN
6′ ^{r}*u*$_3^{1}$ *ki-mu* 3;0.0.0 GUR AŠ$_2$?.AN.NA^{rgiš}BAN$_2$ 5 SILA$_3^{1}$
7′ ^{tug2} GU$_2$.E$_3$ *ki-iz-zi*
8′ $^{m.d}$*nin-urta-qar-rad a-na* ^{m}*ta-ri-bi*
9′ *ḫur-ru-uṣ*
10′ ^{r}*uḫ*^{1} ^{r}*ṭ*^{1}*-tar-ma* ^{m}*ta-ri-bu*
11′ *[i-na muḫ]-ḫi* ŠE.BAR ^{r}*a-na*^{1} $^{m.d}$*nin-urta-qar-rad*
12′

Translation:

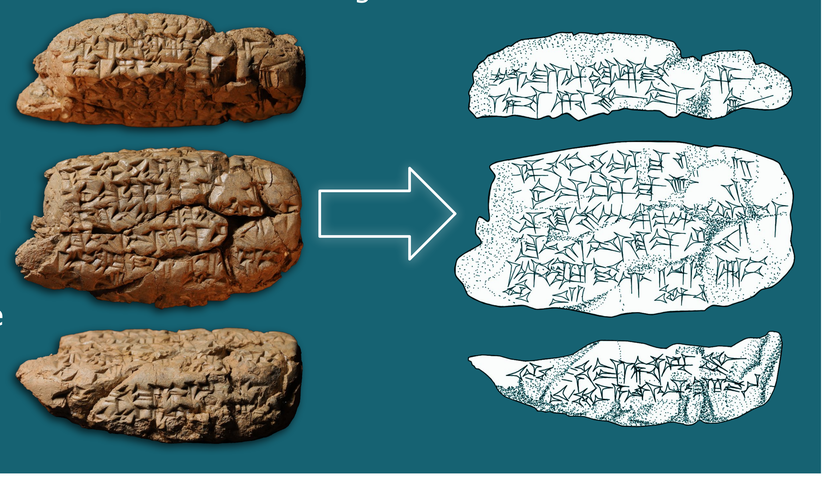
(1′-3′) Tarību received [object in line 1′] from Ninurta-qarrād.
(4′) ditto ditto [2+];1.2.0 malt? measured in the big *sūtu* measure.
(5′) ditto ditto sesame oil measured in the big *sūtu* measure.
(6′-9′) And instead of 3 kor emmer, Ninurta-qarrād *diminish a debt*? for Tarību with a *kizzu*-cloak.
(10′) He will not come back.
(10′-12′) Tarību [will not raise a claim] concerning the barley against Ninurta-qarrād.

Philological Questions:

9′ *ḫurruṣ* (D stative or *ḫarāṣu*) is odd, and to our knowledge not attested in legal context in D stem. With Ninurta-qarrād as a subject, one would expect normally a form of *nadānu*. *ḫarāṣu* is however used in Št "to calculate a deduction" and N "to be deducted" in manners, which make it likely that this could be used here with the meaning "to reduce a debt/outstanding obligation."

3. Reading: Next, we complete a transliteration (identifying cuneiform signs) and translation (identifying the meaning of their combinations). This is done line by line of the tablet. Educated guesses where signs are missing or fragmented are denoted in [brackets]. Questions about readings are marked beneath each line. At this stage, feedback is very valuable until reaching a confident reading.

4. Hand copying: Once readings are as confident as can be, a hand-copy (or 2D drawing of the tablet) can be made by comparing the actual object, the photos of the object, and the transliteration, to inform where lines are drawn.



Challenges: All of the tablets are very fragmentary, if not entirely disintegrated already.

Discussion

Network: A30078 is part of a private archive from House 107, room TA 90, of level IV. Ongoing identification has expanded this archive to 24 tablets, grouped on the basis of findspot, date, and content. The documents are broadly legal and economic in genre.

What we are trying to do: Reading tablets from this archive allows us to build a fuller picture of individuals mentioned, such as Ninurta-qarrad. In the future, we aim to reconstruct their relationships and identify the types of legal and economic transactions they were involved in.



A30082

Significance: This work helps fill a major gap in our knowledge of Kassite Nippur, where many materials remain unpublished, limiting our understanding of everyday life, scribal practices, and local economic activity. Analyzing this archive sheds new light on both this household and the broader social and institutional landscape of the time.

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